

Not Another Word

written by

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based on the life of Hunter S. Thompson

INT. LIVING ROOM

A female figure places a crystal glass on top of a liquor cabinet before walking out of frame.

INT. MILES APARTMENT

Afternoon light bleeds into the yellowed walls of a small New York apartment. The quiet bustling of the living city barely breaks into the perfectly kept den of chaos. There is peace to be found in the quiet suffering.

BEEP. BEEP. BEEP.

The clock strikes 3:00pm.

A figure stirs in the unkept, unwashed bed.

MILES GOODMAN (late 30s) rolls to meet the harbinger of the "morning". A hand stretches out lazily missing its mark.

One eye cocks, and with force the alarm is silenced.

INT. KITCHEN - AFTERNOON

Through an automatic stupor, the first thing he grabs from the kitchen is a bottle of Chivas Regal, located in the cabinet closest to the fridge.

The cap twists.

POP.

A flow of orange caught by the light floods into a crystal glass.

CUT TO:

A hand reaches for a chromatic radio, the dials are crusted black from overuse. A popular song snaps on through the static.

A twist of the dial and it snaps to the news.

CUT TO:

A worn wooden box sits on the windowsill. With effort, the jammed, singular drawer is wrestled open.

Lighters of different shapes are scattered on the right side of the divider, sectioned off by an unmarked pack of cigarettes, surrounded by loose tobacco.

MILES fingers a few lighters before settling on an old sailor's lighter, with a burnt, waxed rope coated with lamp oil.

He steals the pack in a controlled motion and carries on.

CUT TO:

He settles into his chair at his coffee table just as an advert on the radio ends, rolling right into the morning news.

He pulls out a cigarette and FLICKS the lighter.

The cigarette crackles to the flame as he inhales.

Any tension held in his body is released from the night before, a remedy only provided by the first cigarette of the day.

He leans into the room, and scans its assortment.

The coffee table is barren except for neat stacks of newspapers and magazines.

An old banjo clock revolves overhead.

CONTINUOUS:

In the span of an hour, Miles has managed to turn the previously neat stacks, into a dirty array of paper all over his coffee table.

MILES swings out of his chair, almost unaware of the effects of his "early morning" beverage.

Reaching a tin of coffee labeled "Colombia's finest", he places the raw beans into a grinder and disrupts the hum of the radio.

A METALLIC GRIND holds the apartment in contempt. He releases the machine and turns to his kettle, filling it with water, before placing it on an old burner.

INT. LIVING ROOM

A wooden box, shaped like a bearded dragon sits on a silver tray on the coffee table of Miles' living room.

EXT. YUNNAN MOUNTAINS - FLASHBACK

A younger, cleaner looking MILES and his expedition team have reached the top peak of the Yunnan Mountains, where a small village rests.

They are treated to a night of festivities, full of food, song, and dance.

The next morning, in preparation to make the descent down the mountain, MILES is gifted the Yunnan Dragon .

INT. LIVING ROOM

A rising WHISTLING sound comes from the kitchen.

A hand opens the latch on the belly of the yunnan dragon, revealing a hollowed out body filled with cocaine and a silver spoon.

Miles scoops out a healthy portion onto the silver tray, which is distributed into a series of thin white lines.

He does what would naturally occur next... then sits back into the couch and pulls a cigarette from his ear.

He lights it.

The ramblings of a news reporter begin to become over powered by...

CUT TO:

A SCREAMING sound that erupts from the kettle as the water boils over.

EXT. PATIO

MILES sits outside smoking the end of his cigarette. Next to him is a round iron table. Upon it rests his coffee, the bottle of Chivas and the tray of cocaine.

The late afternoon and early autumn weather is most accommodating today and has given him enough warmth from the sunlight for him to remain in his bathrobe.

He pours a splash of whiskey into his coffee.

From his vantage point it's easy for him to observe the streets below. Those people... driving their cars, peddling their bikes, or just doing their best on two legs. Something captivates him.

Miles sips his coffee without breaking focus on the city.

He SNORTS a line of cocaine.

CUT TO:

INT. BATHROOM

A nude Miles is seen behind the translucent shower curtain. The hot water squeals from an old shower head.

His mug and a bottle Chivas rest on the bathroom counter.

He hums to, "I smell a rat" by Howling Wolf, which plays faintly from the kitchen radio.

A fleshy arm emerges from the curtain, fetching the mug.

INT. BEDROOM

Red faced, Miles paces in his room still soaking from his shower. He's holding a red cord phone, and speaks at pace.

MILES CONT'D

... I'm telling you, it's - it's a very, very simple switch that turns what at best is a passing experience to an unreasonably exhilarating one ...

He reaches his dresser, atop of which sits the silver tray of cocaine. Half-hazard lines are drawn on its surface. He leans into the tray, and cleans its surface.

He rises abruptly, swallows, and attempts to reconnect his train of thought.

MILES CONT'D

... The Sheriff and I played a game on his lawn a few weeks back. He had my Ping Beryllium, the 9-iron, and I had his shotgun...

CUT TO:

EXT. THE SHERIFF'S FRONT LAWN

Upon a vast property we find Miles, in the company of the SHERIFF (70s), who is currently in his off duty attire.

They stand on either side of a small wooden table, with an array of golf balls and shotgun shells scattered across its surface.

At the base of the table is a case of beer.

The Sheriff is warming up his swing, his head swiveling between the teed ball and the range of property before him.

Miles stands next to him, holding a shotgun. He raises the barrel to his eye line, and nods to the sheriff.

IN ACTION:

MILES (V.O.)
...and about 100 yards away, we had a
linoleum green and a flag set up.
He was pitching toward the green.
And I was standing about 10 feet
away from him, with the alley-
sweeper. And my objective was to
blow his ball off course, like a
clay pigeon..."

INT. BEDROOM

MILES SNORTS a long line of cocaine off of the silver tray.
The phone lays on the counter so that he can simultaneously
speak and consume the cocaine.

MCGARR
(on the phone)
Jesus Miles what time is it over
there for you?

MILES
Never too early MCGARR, never too
early. I thought by now you should
have known my stance on this sorta
thing...

Silence on the other end. He takes another line.

MILES CONT'D

...Anyways, like I was saying, what you do is replace the
object of the game itself...

Wired beyond compare, he passes all over the room without a
care in his mind about McGarr being able to hear him.

MILES CONT'D

Instead of aiming for a hole 100 yards away, your opponent
rips it long and your job is to shoot it out of the air with
a shotgun...

MCGARR
(overlapping)
Can't really hear you there
Miles...
(a beat)
Miles?

At this point in the day Miles is sufficiently inebriated and gets so emotionally involved in what he is saying that he forgets to remain in close proximity to the phone as he speaks to MCGARR.

MCGARR

Miles?! Can you hear me? MILES???

McGarr hangs up.

Miles is completely unaware that McGarr hung up as he lights a smoke and looks at himself in the mirror.

MILES

I was talking with the Sheriff about it earlier. But in a one-man competition, I'd have to compete against you, say, in both of the arts -- the shooting AND the golfing. The sheriff sure knows how to swing a club but is hopeless even with the sweeper. But if you do the Ryder Cup, you'd have to have the clothing line first. I'm going to write about this for this ESPN column tonight. I'm naming you and the Sheriff as the founding consultants."

MILES continues to talk to himself while putting on a tan suit.

We leave Miles in the bedroom and meet him on the street below his apartment.

EXT. CITY STREETS

Night has fallen on the streets of New York.

Miles rides a bright red vespa on his way to breakfast.

Tucked away in the breast pocket of his suit jacket is a silver flask, which he occasionally sips on.

INT. ASTERS PUB

A WAITER carries a wide circular tray to Miles table with:

3 Heinekens, two margaritas, a coleslaw, a taco salad, a double order of fried onion rings, a carrot cake, an ice cream, and a bean fritter salad, a double order of fried onion rings, a carrot cake, an ice cream, and a bean fritter.

He sits in a booth in the furthest corner of the restaurant, amongst a slew of other families and couples. He's the only one alone but seemingly content to be so.

Some of the children stare at Miles while he eats, even after being told not to.

He settles the tab in cash, gets up and winks at a kid on the way out, Heineken in hand.

CUT TO:

INT. APARTMENT

Miles returns home, swings the door open, hooking his vespa keys and jacket on the hanger.

INT. KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

His fridge is full of a well organized collection of premade meals, grapefruit, alcohol and orange juice.

He pulls out a bottle of Champagne.

INT. STUDY - CONTINUOUS

Miles unlocks the door to his study.

A drafting table stands tall in the center of the room. An old typewriter sits accompanied with a stack of blank pages.

The streetlights shine through the study's eastward facing window and the room glows a deep, sodium vapor orange.

The room is encased with bookshelves. In the right corner of the room there is a stand up television with a substantial collection of VHS tapes.

He quickly selects a tape and puts it into the VHS player. His choice of entertainment for the night is a continuous loop of vintage pornography.

He takes a seat at his desk and grabs the bottle of Chartreuse and twists off the cap.

POP.

The yellow liqueur fills his crystal glass.

His hand pulls open the middle drawer of the drafting table revealing a brown binder with 16 interior sleeves, each containing a sheet of acid, printed with the American flag.

He pulls one tab from the mosaic, and places it on his tongue.

He takes a deep sip of the Chartreuse, then lights a cigarette.

A piece of paper is taken from the pile and slotted in to typewriter.

Miles sits down and is ready to write.

CONTINUOUS:

The night passes through the windowsill and early dawn arrives.

A red cardinal perches itself on the window sill, chirping a lovely tune, and flies away.

The once organized desk is now riddled with notes and scrapped pages. Miles continues to write.

The television screen is blue with white text flashing: TAPE END.

His ashtray is filled with cigarette butts, the bottle of chartreuse has been sapped dry, and the Yunnan dragon has been fully excavated.

A finger powers off the TV.

INT. LIVING ROOM

Miles sips on a glass of orange juice and eats a prepared meal of fettuccine Alfredo and a grapefruit.

The morning news plays in the background.

INT. BATHROOM

MILES stares at himself blankly in the mirror.

He pulls it open, revealing a cabinet filled with white-capped orange bottles.

A hand pulls one of the bottles out, which is labelled, "Halcyon".

He takes out two pills and weighs them in his hand.

He then swallows them with a swig of orange juice, and closes the mirrored cabinet.

INT. BEDROOM

Through the door to his room, we see Miles' arm hanging from his bed. He breathes lightly and lets off the occasional SNORE.

INT. APARTMENT - 2:55PM - BEG OF DAY 2

Shari places the crystal glass back atop his liquor cabinet and straightens a painting on the wall, before leaving.

The alarm from the bedroom begins to sound.

INT. KITCHEN

The kettle is boiling.

Miles raises his head from the refrigerator, a half had gallon of orange juice in hand. He twists the cap, sniffs and swigs. He returns the juice and turns to the counter.

He shoots the remainder of Chivas from his glass and pours another one.

He focuses his attention to the radio that's playing in the living room, and spaces out for a second while leaning on the counter.

He sighs.

EXT. BALCONY

Miles sits in his robe and stares out across the street. A fresh cigarette hangs from his lip, still unlit. His usual company of Chivas , cigarettes, cocaine and coffee sit as still as he does.

Reaching out to the table, he grabs the lighter, a worn in Zippo with the inscription:

"I love the fucking Army, and the Army loves fucking me"

The lighter snaps and sparks his cigarette before he returns it to its peers.

He shifts, leans to the table and inhales a line of cocaine, which is washed down with a hardy sip of Chivas, followed by coffee.

Across the street, Miles observes two different apartments in the same building. Through one of the windows, he sees a family interacting around the dinner table. They set plates and cutlery for the meal to come. A young boy and girl fight for the attention of their father.

Miles smokes.

In the other apartment, a young couple are having rigorous sex.

INT. LIVING ROOM

Now sporting a suit, Miles grabs a new lighter and a fresh pack of smokes. He checks for his wallet and key and his flask. He moves at pace.

On a side table the telephone is placed next to the receiver.

MILES CONT'D

... There was something attractive to their mundanity. And, uh, I was at odds with myself. I think I could only find one interesting in the context of the other. Two, uh, tableau's but only one for me. I have no interest, no keen interest rather, in watching young people fuck. Seeing it in a running parallel was ... well honestly I don't know what I'm talking about ...

Miles puts on his hat and opens the door.

MILES CONT'D

... Hang up for me McGar so I don't have to.

The door closes behind him.

EXT. CITY STREETS

Stopped at a red light, Miles pulls out his flask and takes a hardy swig.

INT. ASTERS PUB

The pub is lively.

Sitting in his normal booth, Miles is fixated on the Television playing above the bar.

It's a talk show, and the guest of honor is Miles.

CUT TO:

INT. TALK SHOW

The talk show host, a man in his late 40's, has figured out a way to make Miles the joke in the room. Miles, wasted, takes no issue with being teased and plays along.

HOST CONT'D

... I heard writers weren't
attractive
folk but c'mon, Miles you're really
leaning into that!

The crowd laughs.

MILES

(mocking)

Aw Jim, I wore my best suit just
for you!

The crowd laughs again.

Miles leans back into his chair, smoking his cigarette. In front of him, on the table, is his crystal glass he has at home.

INT. ASTERS PUB

Miles is pulled out from the television. A waitress, mid 50s, is standing in front of him with a note pad.

MILES

What's that?

WAITRESS

Your order. Will it be the usual?

MILES

Same as always, Joansy.

JOANSY smiles, and walks off back to the kitchen.

Before Miles can return his attention to the television, he notices a child standing at the corner of his booth.

They stare at each other. The kid has a pen and paper in his hand.

MILES

Evening.

The child stares shyly, working up the courage to speak.

CHILD

Can I get your autograph please?

Scanning the room, Miles spots a middle aged man peering in on their interaction, who quickly looks away once he noticed he had been spotted.

MILES

I see, yeah, hand me that pen and wad.

CHILD

Thanks.

The child looks back at his father, who had been monitoring the boy, and smiles.

MILES

Tell me son, you know my name?

The child stares blankly.

MILES

Your father put you up to this?

CHILD

Yes.

MILES

Right. Okay, well at least your honest. Not a lot of that around anymore. Keep that going okay? It will get you about half way there most of the time.

The kid blinks and nods, not really grasping what's going on but trying his best to continue playing his part.

Miles signs the paper and hands it back to the kid. The kid instantly wheels around and heads back to his table.

BEAT.

Sipping on a Margherita, the attention of Miles has been returned to the television again. ESPN highlights buzz dully on the screen

After his meal, Miles embarks towards the door, fixing his coat and hat on the way.

He notices the boy and father are still sitting at their table. While in motion he makes a comment.

MILES

Now don't be selling that. That was your kids hard work not -

As Miles is backing up towards the exit, a group of bikers enters Aster's. They're all wearing leather jackets with patches and sporting long unkept beards. Before Miles can finish his sentence he bumps into one of them, who proceeds to shove Miles back through the glass door of Aster's pub.

CRASH.

Miles lay flat on his back surround by glass on the sidewalk outside. His face has been nicked from the fall.

INT. APARTMENT - NIGHT

The door swings open and Miles stumbles in, he walks into the kitchen to grab his Chivas and a glass, and heads over to the couch where the Yunnan Dragon awaits him.

He takes three swigs and three lines of cocaine before lighting a cigarette, still dazed from his outing.

With effort he rises, the Chivas and Dragon in hand, and walks over to the study.

He places the held items on the floor as he lands at the door of the study.

While fumbling for his keys he leans his shoulder on the door, and it flies open, sending Miles crashing to the ground, kicking over the Chivas.

MILES

Mother fuck!

INT. STUDY

The usual flow that possess Miles from Midnight to morning is missing. The stack of blank pages sits tall next to those filled out to the left of the typewriter, and even more so to the scrapped work that lay in balls at his feet.

On the TV, an old football game is playing.

Sweating and struggling to focus, Miles leans back in his chair, with his arms folded behind his head.

His eyes find a book sitting on the shelf to the left. It's a weathered book, written in Indonesian. A small bookmark sticks out of it's side.

CUT TO:

EXT. INDONESIAN ISLANDS - FLASHBACK

It's a sunny day off the coast of Lombok. The sun is shining through the brilliant clear water. The island, a deep green overgrowth, is surrounded by beaches and rock cliffs.

A younger Miles rides in a small motor boat. He's wearing a sweat stained white button down and a pair of aviators, hiding his sun kissed face.

He steers the boat expertly through a lagoon.

In the boat lie crushed cans of native beer, a tackle box, some tools, and a small brief case sitting in a plastic bag.

From his breast pocket, he pulls out a pack of cigarettes, a small photograph comes out with it. He slows the boat down to a drift as he lights it. A small dock, attached to some fishing huts is in the near distance.

Taking a drag, returning the pack to the pocket, he focuses his attention to the photo.

It's of Miles and two men, between them a massive fish. The men's grins shine in compare to Miles smirk.

MILES

Waste of film and a waste of fish.

He smiles and shoves the photograph back into the pocket with the cigarettes.

He pulls the small cord to restart his motor and after a few tries it sputters to life.

He carries on.

CUT TO:

INT. STUDY

His forehead now rests on the drafts desk, his hands at his side. He turns to the rotary phone on his drafting table and begins dialling.

The phone rings three times.

MCGARR (VOICEMAIL)

You have reached the line of Mason McGarr, please leave your name and number and I will get back to you when I can.

BEEP.

MILES

Hey boss. Your not going to like what I have to say but I'm the type to rip the band aid off and call it how it is. So. I'm pulling the plug on it all. The book, the Paramount deal, all of it. And I'm taking the foot off the gas on this next project too. Think its time for me to make my retreat back out to aspen. Less going on, plenty to do.

Miles lights a fresh cigarette.

MILES CONT'D

... Anyways, I wanted to let you know before those androids come in tomorrow for that interview on me. I'll try you again tomorrow after it all goes down. Godspeed.

Returning the receiver Miles looks out to study window to find the Cardinal, but it does not sing its song.

INT. BATHROOM

Miles tenderly applies a bandage to his forehead, throws back two Halcyon.

He shakes his head at his reflection.

INT. BEDROOM

Miles is passed out as a vacuum whirs in another room.

INT. APARTMENT - 2:30 - BEGINNING OF DAY 3

The fishnet legs of Shari guide the vacuum cleaner between the pathways of furniture in the living room.

She collects the plates, restacks the magazines before stepping out onto the terrace.

She dumps the ashtray out into a small dustpan before looking out over the railing.

A white van, marked with a blue logo reading "Drain Disposal", sits parked across the street. Seeing the van gives her pause

She enters inside and dumps the content of the dustbin before rushing over to the phone.

She begins to dial.

INT. BEDROOM

The alarm blares louder than usual. Miles smacks the clock off the side table, along with a small statue and bottle of aspirin.

The alarm continues.

Miles rouses, and reaches down to the clock, silencing it.

He gets up slowly and staggers to the bathroom.

INT. BATHROOM

Gripping the sink with both hands, Miles stares at himself with disbelief. His bandage has been changed.

EXT. BALCONY

Aviators sit attached to a motionless face. The wind doesn't blow. The birds nor the city are singing.

The coffee on the iron table has lost it's steam. The cigarette, left in the ashtray has burnt through to the butt.

Miles breaks his trance and looks out through the iron rods of his balcony to the apartments across the street. All are dark, shutters and curtains drawn.

He peers down to the street, only the van sits below him.

INT. BEDROOM

Multiple suits hang in a shallow closet. With a jerk, Miles pulls off a navy blue one.

The closet mirror shows him buttoning up a shirt, strapping his belt and fitting the coat. He reaches back into the closet and pulls forward a rack of ties, hanging with the other garments. He fingers a few before settling on a blue, black and white striped one.

INT. LIVING ROOM

With an adjustment, the tie is secure to Miles half shaven neck. He fumbles around, grabbing his keys and checking for his flask.

His eyes catch the telephone. It's been left off of the receiver.

He motions towards it, and places the receiver back to its body. He stares, swigs his shot of Chivas from his crystal cup, and sets it on a nearby shelf.

He checks himself in a nearby mirror and wipes the residue of cocaine from his nose.

The locks click, the door opens, and he departs.

EXT. ASTERS

His usual spot is filled, so Miles had to accept a parking space near the dumpster in the back of Asters.

He circles the establishment, cigarette in mouth and pauses at the entrance.

A large piece of plywood sits where the shattered window used to sit. A small sign hanging from it reading "Please use other door" makes him smirk.

He enters.

INT. ASTERS PUB

As Miles begins to drift towards his booth he first notices it has been occupied by a young couple. He goes to turn to the bar but is promptly met by Joansy.

MILES
(motioning to the broken
door)
Some tab you'll have me paying.

JOANSY
It's no issue hun.

MILES
Hog riders picked it up?

JOANSY
We're insured for such things.

MILES
(looking past her at his
table)
Right, right. Weren't, uh,
expecting me tonight?

Joansy's dutiful demeanor shifts to a kinder stance.

JOANSY
We're not supposed to be expecting
you.

MILES
I'm not following.

JOANSY
(passive, half hearted)
We've had some heavier business
tonight, needed the larger tables.

Glancing around the room Miles notices multiple booths are
not in use, contrary to her comments.

MILES
To the bar then.

He goes to move past her but she puts a tender hand on his
shoulder.

JOANSY
Maybe not tonight.

MILES
This about the door?

JOANSY
More ... circumstantial, than
anything, really.

He ponders a second, and drops his shoulders in defeat.

MILES
I heard Allan's has a good Galway
chowder, I'll be off then.

JOANSY
I heard the same. For those who had
the time.

Her comment strikes Miles as odd. He glances up to the
wooden clock above the bar.

He double checks the time on his wrist watch.

MILES
Good call. Evening then.

He turns and heads out the door he came from.

EXT. ASTERS

Miles looks back as the door closes and checks his watch again. He lights a cigarette and circles the pub back to his Vespa.

INT. LIVING ROOM

Amber Chivas swirls the crystal glass in the palm of Miles.

The room is dimly lit, as the bulb of the sole lamp in the room has been stained black from the excessive exposure to cigarette smokes.

The Yunnan Dragon sits in front of him, a small pile of cocaine in front of it on the silver tray.

Miles has switched his suit for a Tan one, having also ditched the tie. His leg bounces as he glances from the clock, place to place and back to the clock.

He checks his watch to confirm the integrity of both time pieces.

MILES
(muttering)
Christ, not even Nixon drew anxiety
from the press.

He stands, paces to the window, glances down at the van and returns to his seat.

He lifts the tray to his lap, inhales some cocaine off the tray, and resets it.

He finishes his glass, refills it and settles back in, glancing at his watch again.

The creak of the elevator in the outside hall precedes the sounds of footsteps outside his door.

KNOCK. KNOCK. KNOCK.

Before opening the door, Miles is reminded of the exposed cocaine on the tray. He wipes it away, licking his fingers after its dispersion.

Opening the door, he is greeted by a middle aged WOMAN (late 30s) and two MEN (late 30s), both holding large black cases.

WOMAN
(extending her hand to
shake.)
Miles Goodman, it is a pleasure.

Miles shakes her hand and eyes her two male companions.

MILES
Likewise, uh, Laura was it?

WOMAN
Laura is my assistant, you spoke to
her on the phone, I'm Stacey
Bradshaw.

MILES
Right, apologies for that.

STACEY
No apologies necessary, it's nice
to
meet you in person. This is our
small crew, Michael and Michael.

Her smile matches her grey sports coat and pencil skirt,
smart and professional. The men behind her are both wearing
black t-shirts with matching black pants. One has a black
toque.

MILES
Michael and Michael. What are they,
brothers?

Neither men respond. Stacey smiles.

MILES
Bad joke. Pleasure.

The men shake hands.

STACEY
May we come in?

MILES
Sure hope so, yeah.

Miles turns and vacates the door, letting the crew enter the
house.

The two Michaels spend no time taking in the apartment and
get to work opening their cases. They pull out a camera,
tripod and a couple small lights, along with a microphone
attached to a pole. They open side pockets, and small hidden
folds in the cases pulling out cables and lenses.

Stacey sits adjacent to Miles.

STACEY
Is that seat where you like to be interviewed.

MILES
Yep, that's fine.

STACEY
Anywhere you feel comfortable.

MILES
Perfect right here yeah.

Miles attention is still fixed on the men setting up the gear. He watches them as they slowly build the room into a television set, shifting tables, collecting loose magazines.

STACEY
So I'll go over the basis of what questions will be laid out to you throughout our interview, just to avoid blind spots.

MILES
(having half heard her)
Never really understood the camera much.

STACEY
Pardon me?

The camera sits on top of it's case, staring back at Miles.

MILES
I don't see how you could possibly make a true film. Because if I bring all of this machinery, you uh create a situation thats unnatural anyway. Its not you, I think its actually one of the main problems with film.

STACEY
In your line of work I'd have thought you'd have spent plenty of time in front of the camera.

MILES

Sure but still, I don't understand film that well, that's one of the reasons I want to learn about film. Technology is not at the level where you can actually portray reality. The technology warps reality its a betrayal. Film interests me, id like to -

CRASH.

Miles is cut off by one of the small studio lights collapsing to the ground.

MICHAEL

Apologies about that. Damn turn screw.

STACEY

You were saying

MILES

(waving her off)

Ahh.

Miles gets up and heads to his bar cart. Picking up a fresh bottle of Chartreuse, he turns back to Stacey.

MILES

You mind?

STACEY

Not at all.

MILES

Care to join in?

STACEY

I'm perfectly fine thanks.

MILES

Smoke?

STACEY

Sure.

Miles sits back down and before pouring the bottle, he pulls out his pack of cigarettes and offers one to Stacey. He shifts, pulls a lighter from his pocket and lights both cigarettes.

One of the Michaels sets the lights on the them.

MICHAEL
(approaching)
Just gonna grab levels and we
should be ready to get going.

The other Michael is setting the old camera onto the tripod and framing the shot.

Stacey takes a heavy drag of her cigarette, smiles and puts it out in the ashtray.

BEAT.

The interview has begun, Miles across from Stacey in the warm glow of the small studio lights. With one Michael on the camera, the other operates a boom microphone, and holds the pole above the heads of interviews subjects.

Miles smokes and drinks, and is as comfortable as he would be without the present company.

STACEY CONT'D
... are you saying you miss
travelling?

MILES
No, not particularly. A story is
uh, a - a story and it can be found
and written any way you like it.
There's no sense in travelling for
stories, you travel for you. It's
all up to you.

STACEY
But your current lifestyle, that we
have just gone over. Waking up in
the afternoon, and immediately
start to drink and use substances,
and then to not leave your house
till the evening and ... well
consume a days worth of food in a
sitting! Do you not think this
hinders, you or?

MILES

Most people are surprised that I walk on two legs and uh, they idea that I would have a wife or a child, is, even a mother, it seems surprising. But to answer it's no. Most find themselves the product of where they are or , uh, what they do but I'm my own product. I uh, what's that quote - darn - anyways, this is no hinderance, your life is as, uh, queer to me as mine is in your eyes right.

STACEY

I see. But in the quality of your work. You've found no lapse.

MILES

For there to be a lapse in my writting there would need to be a lapse in me.

He loses focus and stares off to the Yunnan dragon. It's been a few hours since he's emptied it.

MILES

Could we take a break, I'm losing sense here.

STACEY

We're almost through, Miles just a few more questions. Would you mind carrying on?

He looks down at his glass, the Chartreuse has been emptied and reduced to a mouthful in the crytal cup.

MILES

Yeah alright.

He looks past the camera and the lights.

MILES

You good with that fellas?

They both give Miles the thumbs up without moving from their posts.

Stacey repositions herself, flattening the breast of her suit.

STACEY

What is next for Miles Goodman?

MILES

Don't even think the Lord could
tell you that much.

STACEY

You've tackled political
journalism, satire, sports
reporting and biographic depiction
- is there a new area of,
storytelling, that you would like
to engage with?

Staring blankly through Stacey, Miles finishes the last sip
of his glass. He glances over to the phone. It's been pulled
off of the receiver.

MILES

I can't, uh say that the pen is dry
but, perhaps something else has
become barren.

STACEY

Elaborate on that.

MILES

I think I have taken that form as
far as I can take it, writing that
is. I've found that I have started
repeating myself, anyway its not as
much fun anymore, it's hard for me
to work on a story, I become part
of the story.

He pauses.

MILES CONT'D

First time I went to a press
conference with Jimmy Carter I had
to sign more autographs than Carter
had to sign...

CUT TO:

EXT. CHIGACO - FLASHBACK

A brazen crowd stands on the city streets. People cheer and
scream from all directions. Miles, in the middle of the
heap, trying to keep eyes on the event is pull away by
multiple patrons.

CUT TO:

INT. APARTMENT - PRESENT

MILES CONT'D

And the secret service had no idea who I was they thought I was an astronaut. I used to be able to stand in the back, absorb stories and observe them. I can't do that anymore. Now I appear in the story and I become apart of it. At the same time my collective works are coming out in the fall in this huge book and so I am really in the way as a person ... the myth has taken over and you know, I find myself as an appendage. I'm no longer necessary. I'm in the way...

Stacey glances back to her crew, they both signal to her with their eyes, and nod. She refocuses.

MILES CONT'D

... It would be much better if I died, so people could take the myth. I have no choice, I have to solve this problem... So I supposed my plans are to figure out some new identity I have to kill off one life and start with another one.

STACEY

But this book deal, the picture being produced by Paramount, you don't see these as a peak to your career?

MILES

I've been in the mountains Stacey, and any good climber will tell you. There is no peak, getting up to view the world is one thing, coming down is another.

STACEY

So you have concern for your legacy once you're dead?

This snaps Miles out of his rant. He grasps where he is shifts with unease.

MILES

I haven't the faintest clue.

STACEY

If you could preserve yourself, if you knew the myth, as you say, could hold the world to that view you created. Would you stop writing?

MILES

Uh, well, sorry I'm not following, are you asking if I died would I - run that by again.

STACEY

Would you be happier dead.

Miles notices that both Michaels are watching him and not the equipment. Stacey hasn't broken eye contact.

MILES

I think we ought to take a break.

Ignoring his suggestion, Stacey pulls out a newspaper, rolled up with a rubber band from her hand bag. She undoes the keeping of the paper.

STACEY

Miles, I would like you to take a look at this.

She hands him the paper. It comes across as an average print: headline, sports column, personal pieces.

STACEY

Page 3.

Miles flips through it and reads something that he refocuses on.

On the right side of the page is the photo of him in Lombok, followed by an obituary.

Folding the paper, and bringing it closer to his face Miles scans it's contents. It highlights his birthplace, early life, his first journalism gig, his travel writing, his first successful fiction, the woman he loved - all of it.

He looks up.

MILES

Fuck is this, kind of cruel joke?

STACEY

It's tomorrow's paper.

Her demeanour has changes. She sits upright and rigid.

The two Michaels are now standing in front of the lights and camera.

MILES

I - I have, have you slipped me something?

STACEY

No at all. Shock is normal in this circumstance.

MILES

What shock - you handed me some sixth grade project to what, enhance this here interview?

The two Michaels flank Miles. They stand on either side of him now. The one to his right kneels next to him and begins opening a small black bag.

MILES

What the fuck are you -

He goes to stand but is pressed down into his seat by the man to his left.

To his right, Michael pulls a stethoscope, and grabs the arm of Miles to begin listening to his pulse.

Miles looks back, helplessly at Stacey for answers.

STACEY

This is always the most frightening part. But I promise, you will come to understand what is happening. We don't have the freedom to elaborate due to past experiences but this will all take shape for you Miles.

MILES

Fuck are you talking about.

The stethoscope is returned to the bag and syringe is pulled out by Michael and inserted into the neck of Miles.

MILES

Jesus Christ the fuck are you doing, get the fuck off me you - get the fuck out of here.

He begins to fade.

EXT. APARTMENT - ENDING 1

The sun is beginning to rise. It paints away the shadows of the brick apartments, filtering through the trees and warming the dewed ground below.

Michael and Michael stand on either side of a gurney, pushing it toward the open door of a white van.

Stacey stands smoking, arms crossed.

The gurney has a black body bag on top, straps along the chest and legs.

They halt at the van.

STACEY

We're certain we've collected everything?

MICHAEL

Yeah, everything listed in the study and bedroom was accounted for.

STACEY

And all our gear, too right?

MICHAEL

All of it.

STACEY

You will be held to that.

The two Michaels exchange a glance.

MICHAEL

You know it wasn't us on the Millar job right.

STACEY

Doesn't matter. We're all under the gun here.

MICHAEL

Well we're good. It's all here.

STACEY

Well let's get him inside and take off.

The two men load the gurney into the van with ease, and secure the body so it remains fixed.

Stacey walks to the passenger seat and Michael gets into the drivers seat, starting the engine and slamming the door.

The other Michael closes the sliding back door, revealing the blue logo:

"Sidman's Retirement Facility"

The van takes off down the road.

INT. WELCOME ROOM - ENDING 2

Miles sits in a chrome chair with grey wool arm rests, matching the carpet. The textured plaster walls are lit by overhead hanging tube lights and fogged out windows.

Behind him a wooden door, with no handle, surrounded by more fogged out windows. There is occasional movement behind it.

He stirs.

First he peaks open his right eye, cocking his head back and gaining his surroundings, before opening his left.

He stretches his legs out and massages his neck before checking his pockets for his cigarettes.

He looks forward, beginning to sober up and notices the projector screen in front of him. It buzzes with light, but no film inside.

MILES

What the fuck is going on here.

Miles looks behind him and sees movement, and repeats himself in their direction.

MILES

What the FUCK. Hello?

He goes to stand but the scratch of speakers turning on startles him. The projector begins to whirl.

VOICE (V.O)

Good Morning Miles Goodman!

The screen reads the same in plane black font.

Miles settles back into his chair, mouth agape from utter disbelief.

The screen begins to show a parade of footage. Different facilities, restaurants, common areas, community centers, sports fixtures etc.

VOICE (V.O)

Welcome to the Sidman's Retirement Facility. We have been anticipating your arrival. Before we begin, we can understand your confusion. Please trust in knowing that every and all questions you have will be answered in due process. But in the time being, please do your best to calm your nerves and listen to the following message. Sidman's Retirement Facility is an incredibly exclusive opportunity for those deemed important figures to our society. We are incredibly privileged to have you with us! Our goal is preservation. We aim to collect those important voices who have lost their tune, and to preserve their legacy in the public eye. Not only will we encourage your rehabilitation, we will also seek to elevate your works to heights that would not be reachable without your sudden, and untimely death.

Miles hands are over his face, his mouth is still agape.

VOICE (V.O)

We know what you're thinking - 'but I am not dead!'. That is exactly our mission. To offer you, and your careers, the ultimate reward without having to pay the ultimate price. Please focus your attention to the screen.

The film cuts for a moment and then flips to a news reel. The anchor is standing outside Miles apartment. Below him is the headline written - "Miles Goodman - Found dead in apartment at age XX"

NEWSMAN

Earlier this morning, the body of esteemed writer and journalist, Miles Goodman was found in his New York apartment, dead from an apparent overdose. Authorities say that after several attempts to be contacted from close friends and colleagues, they breached his apartment to find him in his study. Traces of Cocaine ...

The clip mutes. The voice over continues.

VOICE (V.O)

This will run across the country.
We have taken the strenuous liberty
of staging your death. Your affairs
and unfinished works have been
collected by us and will be
released to correct the final days
of your career, assuring you are
recognized and well loved for years
to come, rather than to fade into
obscurity.
We know this a lot to understand.
We know you must have many
questions. In just a few moments,
our founder and chairman Lance
Sidman will join you to answer all
those questions and get you started
with your new life in retirement.
We are so happy to have you with us
and hope you enjoy your stay.

The projector cuts. The silence is deafening. Miles has not moved a muscle.

BEAT.

The door begins to jostle from behind Miles. He slightly turns to find a man, accompanied by an aide enter in. He wears a smart grey suit, well pressed and tailored. The woman wears a white lab coat.

MAN

Hi Miles. It's good to have you
with us. I'm Doctor Lance Sidman.
Welcome to retirement.

